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Vegetarians rejoice. There's a new kid on the block to take care of most of your protein requirements, and what's more, there's nothing fake about it! Tempeh, traditional to Indonesians and a part of their diet for centuries, has caught the imagination of people globally over the past few years as a meat substitute and is now making inroads into Indian kitchens as well.

The tempeh craze is riding on the plant-based protein wave all over the world. The global tempeh market, valued at \$3.8 billion in 2022, is expected to reach \$6.3 billion by 2032, expanding at a CAGR of 5.3%, according to DataHorizon Research, a market research and consulting firm.

So, what exactly is tempeh, and why is it becoming popular? Tempeh is basically fermented soya bean, where soya bean is cooked, dehulled, and then combined with a starter culture containing a specific strain of fungus called *Rhizopus oligosporus*. This fungus binds the soya bean together, forming a dense cake-like structure with a whitish mycelium network. This can then be sliced and diced and used for cooking. It has 60% water, 20% protein, 8% carbohydrates, and about 12% fat.

Tempeh is firmer than tofu and has a grainier texture and nuttier flavour, making it more versatile. But it is tempeh's gut-enhancing quality—which helps boost the immune system—that

has got the world to sit up and take note. "Tempeh is fermented, so [it] is easy to digest. It provides calcium, magnesium, zinc, and lots of vitamin B, besides of course being a high source of protein. It has 19 gm of protein per 100 gm, making it an ideal source of protein, especially for vegetarians," says Kavita Devgan, a Delhi-based nutritionist and author of books such as *The Don't-Diet Plan* and *The Immunity Diet*.

Chefs are beginning to experi-

The Spice Route. In fact, he was so convinced of tempeh's qualities (both in terms of nutrition and its versatility in the kitchen) that he decided to make tempeh in-house at the hotel, instead of buying it from the handful of start-ups selling it in India. "Tempeh is traditionally made of soya bean, but we are making it with lobia beans, which are more indigenous," says Gadang.

Adds Arun Sundaraj, Director of Culinary Operations at Taj



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ment with it and are enjoying it. In February, when The Spice Route, an iconic restaurant at New Delhi's Imperial Hotel, changed its menu after almost three decades to provide dishes inspired by the ancient trade route from East Asia through Java to India, it introduced tempeh on the menu. "I wanted to introduce something that was an alternative to tofu, which I feel is not really preferred by the Indian market," says Mustian Gadang, Chef de Cuisine at

Mahal, New Delhi, who uses tempeh at popular restaurants House of Ming and Machan at the hotel: "While tempeh is a lot like tofu, it has a higher [level of] protein content and is less processed than tofu. Though it may be considered a meat substitute, it has its own status on the menu."

Tempeh can be fried, simmered, or grilled. Its texture and ability to absorb flavours make it a perfect base for marinating. "People are not eating it only as a